Helen Devine
Yale Social/Personality Psychology Statement of Academic Purpose

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As a social psychologist, I hope to study how people make judgments about victimhood and blame, especially when lay judgments contradict legal standards. My past research experiences have given me extensive preparation to explore these questions and Yale's Social/Personality Psychology PhD program is the best place for me to conduct graduate training.

I began exploring social psychology during my freshman year at the University of Michigan, where I worked as a study coordinator in Dr. Amie Gordon's Well-Being, Health, and Interpersonal Relationships Lab on a large-scale longitudinal study of how romantic couples navigate stress. I designed recruitment to bring 218 couples into the lab, ran in-person lab sessions using the Trier Social Stress Test, collected biopsychological data (continuous heart rate, blood pressure, salivary hormones), and coordinated a subsequent two-week daily diary. I also ran follow-ups for a year to track changes in relational quality over time. Learning to manage multiple physiological methods gave me an early foundation in rigorous experimental design.

Before my junior year, I was selected as Dr. Gordon's lab manager, a position typically reserved for post-baccalaureates. In collaboration with Dr. Robin Edelstein, I helped launch a study on how romantic couples adapt to first-time parenting by caring for an infant simulator for a weekend. I oversaw the collection of over 2,000 saliva samples and trained our team on an enzyme-linked immunosorbent assay technique. We found that couples with positive expectations about parenting showed decreased testosterone when caring for the infant simulator, suggesting that optimism helps parents adapt more readily to a nurturing role. I am a co-author on the manuscript with an R&R in *Human Nature*. My early work at Michigan taught me how powerfully social context shapes behavior and judgments of others, even our closest partners.

My interest in high-stakes decision-making under social pressure took shape through my senior honors thesis. I designed two experiments and secured $4,000 in independent funding to test whether the presence of a close friend makes people less likely to comply with an intrusive phone search request ("Can you please unlock your phone and hand it to me?"). Participants overwhelmingly handed over their phones—whether alone or with a friend—despite predicting that they would not comply. Additionally, even bystanders showed heightened physiological arousal (e.g., spiked systolic blood pressure) when watching their friends comply, providing evidence that intrusive requests evoke a stress response that likely affects predicted behavior. I presented this work as a talk at the 2025 *Society for Personality and Social Psychology* legal psychology pre-conference, received the faculty-nominated Pillsbury Award for best thesis, and graduated with Highest Honors. This work showed me how quickly people make high-stakes decisions, which pushed me to explore how this same rapid judgment process shapes moral evaluations.

To expand my training, I earned a lab manager position in Dr. Kurt Gray's Deepest Beliefs Lab at UNC Chapel Hill, which later moved to The Ohio State University. In an ongoing first-authored project, I am investigating whether fear of crime increases victim-blaming. My results suggest that those who fear victimization are more likely to blame victims, potentially to resolve cognitive dissonance. This suggests that efforts to raise awareness about crime may inadvertently

increase blame rather than protect victims. I have presented these findings at two national conferences and expanded the project into an NSF Graduate Research Fellowship application. I aim to use this research to reduce victim-blaming by targeting how crime is reported nationally.

My goal as a scientist is to use psychology not only to understand people, but to improve the systems that shape their lives. Alongside my empirical work with Dr. Gray, I co-authored an accepted piece in *Policy Insights from the Behavioral and Brain Sciences* on how psychological perceptions of victimhood diverge from legal expectations. This piece strengthened my interest in understanding why people judge some individuals more harshly than others, especially when those judgments carry real consequences.

These experiences have inspired me to pursue graduate studies to understand how people make moral judgments in legal contexts. Yale's Social/Personality PhD program is the ideal place for me to develop this work, and I am especially excited about the possibility of being advised by Dr. Melissa Ferguson. I am drawn to Dr. Ferguson's research on how people form rapid impressions of others and how these impressions influence behavior. My work on fear-driven victim-blaming raises parallel questions about why some individuals are judged more harshly, and how contextual cues shape evaluations. I am also eager to investigate how people update their social and legal judgments when presented with new information. "Victim" or "perpetrator" labels often persist even in the face of disconfirming evidence, and I hope to study the cognitive and affective processes that make these judgments so hard to update. I see opportunities for collaboration with Dr. Yarrow Dunham on group-based evaluations and with Dr. Tom Tyler on how perceptions of authority and compliance guide legal decision-making.

Yale's emphasis on social cognition, law, and rigorous experimental methodology make it uniquely suited for my intellectual goals. The opportunity to work across labs with complementary strengths would allow me to study how people form judgments in everyday situations and in consequential institutional contexts. I am excited by the prospect of contributing to this collaborative community.